Zhuoyu (Rachel) Qiu

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Research Interests

My research focuses on applied microeconomics, particularly labor economics and the economics of education. I study how educational and family environments shape human capital accumulation, with particular attention to gender disparities and child well-being, using large-scale administrative data and causal inference methods.

Education

• University of California, Riverside — Riverside, CA, USA
Ph.D. in Economics — *Sep. 2021 – Jun. 2027 (expected)*

• Jinan University — Guangzhou, China
M.S. in Economics, with Honors — *Sep. 2019 – Jun. 2021*

• Zhongnan University of Economics and Law — Wuhan, China
B.S. in Economics, with Honors — *Sep. 2014 – Jun. 2019*

Job Market Paper

• Gender Peer Effects and Women's Academic Performance in Mathematics: Evidence from a U.S. University [Link]

Abstract: Understanding how educational environments shape women's mathematics achievement and persistence can help explain their continued underrepresentation in mathematics-intensive fields despite rising educational attainment. This paper examines how classroom gender composition affects women's academic performance in introductory mathematics courses at university. Using administrative records for freshmen entering a selective U.S. public university between 2016 and 2023, I exploit variation in female peer share across classes in a specific introductory mathematics course taught by a given instructor within a single academic term, allowing for gender-specific responses.

A 10-percentage-point increase in female peer share raises women's probability of completing introductory mathematics by approximately 3.1 percentage points and earning C- or better by approximately 3.4 percentage points. Both women and men experience improvements in broader first-quarter academic progress, with limited evidence of gender differences in the baseline effects. The findings are robust to controlling for gender composition in other courses and excluding pandemic-entry cohorts.

Women's benefits are concentrated among students who declared a STEM major at entry, while comparable positive effects do not emerge in other entry-term subjects. Longer-term estimates are consistent with increased STEM degree attainment among STEM entrants, although they remain imprecise. These findings highlight classroom gender composition as a factor supporting women's progress through foundational university mathematics.

Publication

[1] Qiu, Z. (2026). **Punching Out, Not Down: The Impact of Paid Sick Leave on Child Maltreatment**. *Labour Economics*, 102958. doi:10.1016/j.labeco.2026.102958. **[Link]**

Selected Work in Progress

• Effects of Faculty Gender Attitudes on College Students' Short- and Long-Term Outcomes

With Radhika Bansal (University of California, Riverside), Ozkan Eren (University of California, Riverside), Krzysztof Karbownik (Emory University), and Ruinan Zhao (State of California Department of Industrial Relations)

- We link university administrative records (2013–2024) to faculty responses on the Gender-Science Implicit Association Test to examine student achievement, major choice, STEM persistence, graduation, and earnings outcomes.
- Preliminary findings indicate that female students taught by instructors with stronger implicit gender bias are more likely to leave their declared majors and less likely to graduate on time.

• The Impact of Marriage Tax Bonus and Penalty on Marital Decisions in the U.S.

With Zhe Yang (Liaoning University)

- We examine marriage formation and dissolution using the Survey of Income and Program Participation. We measure marriage tax bonuses and penalties relative to after-tax income and construct an instrument using variation in tax incentives across states and demographic groups.
- Our results show that, for cohabiting couples, a 1% increase in the MB-to-income ratio leads to a 0.12% increase in the likelihood of getting married. For married couples, the elasticity of the MB-to-income ratio to the likelihood of marital dissolution is -0.14%.

Technical and Policy Reports

[1] Bates, M., Bruene, S., Calderon, E. E., De La Torre, E., Freire, P., Guo, J., Hutchins, G. B., Jackson, K., Kapoor, M., Nelson, F., **Qiu, Z.**, Reese, E., Rettberg, G., and Tamayose, B. C. (2023). **The State of Work in the Inland Empire Part II: Pandemic, Polarization, Inflation, and Investment.** *Inland Empire Labor and Community Center and Center for Social Innovation, University of California, Riverside.* [**Link**]

[2] Bainiwal, T. S., Bates, M., Brookes, M., Bruene, S., Calderon, E., Carranza, N., De La Torre, E., Freire, P., Gudis, C., Guo, J., Hutchins, G. B., Jackson, K., Kapoor, M., Nelson, F., **Qiu, Z.**, Reese, E., Rettberg, G., Tamayose, B., and Tan, A. (2024). **The State of Work: Transportation, Distribution, and Logistics in the Inland Empire.** *Inland Empire Labor and Community Center and Center for Social Innovation, University of California, Riverside.* [**Link**]

[3] Bates, M., Brookes, M., Bruene, S., Burnett, J., Calderon, E., Carbajal, A., De La Torre, E., Guo, J., Hutchins, G. B., Kapoor, M., Mukenge, K., Nelson, F., **Qiu, Z.**, Rana, S., Reese, E., Rettberg, G., Salam, I., and Tamayose, B. (2024). **Thrive Inland SoCal: Labor Market Analysis.** *Inland Empire Labor and Community Center and Center for Social Innovation, University of California, Riverside.* [**Link**]

Teaching Experience

• **University of California, Riverside** — Riverside, CA, USA

Instructor of Record — *Aug. 2025*

- Urban Economics *(Summer 2025)*

Teaching Assistant — *Oct. 2022 – Present*

- Introductory Econometrics *(Fall 2022; Winter 2023; Winter & Fall 2024; Winter, Spring, & Fall 2025; Winter 2026)*
- Statistics for Economics *(Fall 2023)*
- Intermediate Microeconomic Theory *(Spring 2024; Spring 2026)*

Software Instructor — *Jul. – Aug. 2023*

- Stata Boot Camp, Master of Public Policy Program

Pedagogical Training — *Jul. 2026*

- Summer Curriculum Design Institute

Research Experience

• **Department of Economics, University of California, Riverside** — Riverside, CA, USA
Graduate Student Researcher — *Jul. – Sep. 2026*

• **Center for Social Innovation, University of California, Riverside** — Riverside, CA, USA
Graduate Student Researcher — *Apr. – Jun. 2023*

• **Peking University HSBC Business School** — Remote
Research Assistant — *Dec. 2020 – Jun. 2021*

• **Guangzhou Academy of Social Sciences** — Guangdong, China
Research Assistant — *Aug. – Dec. 2020*

Presentations and Talks

• Economic Seminar Series, California State University Long Beach *(scheduled)* — Long Beach, CA, USA, *2026*

• Southern Economic Association (SEA) 96th Annual Meeting *(department nominated, scheduled)* — Houston, TX, USA, *2026*

• International Symposium on Contemporary Labor Economics, Xiamen University — Xiamen, China, *2025*

• Southern Economic Association (SEA) 95th Annual Meeting — Tampa, FL, USA, *2025*

• Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM) Annual Fall Conference — Seattle, WA, USA, *2025*

• 18th All-California Labor Economics Conference, Stanford University — Stanford, CA, USA, *2025*

• China Economics Society (CES) China Annual Conference, Sun Yat-sen University — Guangzhou, China, *2025*

• SEMi-Talk Academic Workshop, Tsinghua University — Beijing, China, *2024*

• 15th All-California Labor Economics Conference, University of California, Riverside — Riverside, CA, USA, *2022*

Referee Service

• Journal of Labor Research

Honors and Awards

• Dean's Distinguished Fellowship, University of California, Riverside — *2021 – Present*

• Outstanding Graduate Award, Jinan University — *2019 – 2021*

Skills

Software: Stata, Python, MATLAB, R, SQL, LaTeX, Qualtrics

Additional Skills: Policy report writing, survey design, data visualization

References

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